QP CODE - 25901354

MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR EXAMINATION March 2026 Fourth SEMESTER

Discipline Specific Elective (DSE) - MG4DSEJMC200

Discipline Specific Core Course (DSC) - MG4DSCPJM202 - UNDERSTANDING CINEMA

Duration: 2 hours **Maximum Marks : 70**

PART A — Multiple Choice Questions

1a) First horror film

2b) Edison's company

3b) It combined Expressionist style with science fiction

4a) Apu Trilogy

5b) Comedy and pathos

6c) Gives deeper analysis

7b) Shooting

8b) American Old West

9d) Add deeper meaning

10b) French theatre tradition

PART B — Short Answer Questions *(3 Marks)*

11. Edison's Contribution to the Commercialisation of Cinema

- Thomas Edison and his laboratory developed the Kinetoscope (1891), a peep-hole device that allowed individual viewers to watch short films, establishing the commercial potential of moving images
- Edison's company produced some of the earliest filmed content, including Fred Ott's Sneeze (1894), and built the Black Maria — the first dedicated film production studio
- By controlling key patents through the Motion Picture Patents Company (MPPC), Edison shaped the early commercial structure of the film industry, though his model was eventually displaced by the Hollywood studio system

12. Conventions of the Horror Genre

- Horror films conventionally feature a threatening antagonist — monster, ghost, serial killer, or supernatural force — that disrupts the safety and normalcy of the protagonists' world
- Standard conventions include isolated settings, darkness, suspenseful music and sound design, jump scares, and the gradual revelation of danger to build dread
- The genre typically follows a structure in which order is disrupted by evil, characters are eliminated one by one, and a final confrontation determines survival — often with an ambiguous or shocking conclusion

13. Persistence of Vision

- Persistence of vision is the physiological phenomenon whereby the human eye retains an image on the retina for a fraction of a second after the image has disappeared

- When a rapid sequence of still images is projected — typically at 24 frames per second — this retention creates the illusion of continuous, smooth motion
- This optical principle is the foundational scientific basis upon which cinema and all moving image media operate, allowing static photographs to create the perception of life and movement

14. Role of Long Takes in Cinematic Storytelling

- A long take is an uninterrupted shot of extended duration that allows action to unfold in real time without the intervention of editing cuts
- Long takes create a sense of realism and spatial continuity, immersing the viewer in the scene and allowing performances to develop naturally without fragmentation
- Directors such as Orson Welles, Alfonso Cuarón, and Andrei Tarkovsky used long takes as expressive tools to build tension, demonstrate directorial control, and establish an observational, contemplative relationship between the camera and its subjects

15. Review vs. Summary

- A summary is a neutral, objective retelling of a film's plot — describing what happens in the story without offering evaluative judgement or analytical insight
- A review combines a brief account of the film's content with the critic's informed evaluation of its artistic, technical, and thematic qualities, including performance, direction, screenplay, and cinematography
- While a summary serves only to inform about plot events, a review guides audience decision-making and contributes to critical discourse about the film as a cultural and artistic work

16. Definition of Script

- A script, or screenplay, is the written document that serves as the blueprint for a film, containing all dialogue, scene descriptions, character directions, and narrative structure
- It is the primary creative document from which all departments — direction, production design, acting, cinematography — derive their work
- Scripts follow a standardised format with scene headings (sluglines), action lines, and character dialogue, and exist in various stages including the treatment, first draft, and shooting script

17. Practical Effects vs. Digital Effects

- Practical effects are physical, real-world techniques achieved on set during production — including miniatures, prosthetics, makeup, pyrotechnics, mechanical rigs, and in-camera optical illusions
- Digital effects (VFX) are created in post-production using computer-generated imagery (CGI) to add, enhance, or replace visual elements that were not present during filming
- Practical effects offer tangible realism and interact authentically with actors and lighting, while digital effects provide limitless creative possibilities; contemporary filmmaking typically combines both for optimal results

18. Black Maria

- The Black Maria was the world's first purpose-built film production studio, constructed by Thomas Edison and William Dickson in 1893 at Edison's laboratory complex in West Orange, New Jersey
- The structure was covered in black tar paper — giving it its nickname — and was built on a rotating pivot that allowed it to follow the sun's direction to maximise natural light on the subject being filmed
- It was used to produce early Kinetoscope films featuring vaudeville performers, boxers, and novelty acts, making it the originating site of commercial film production in America

19. Importance of Marketing in Film Distribution

- Marketing creates audience awareness and anticipation for a film through trailers, posters, press tours, social media campaigns, and promotional events before and during release
- Effective marketing directly determines a film's opening weekend performance — the most commercially critical period — by generating sufficient public interest to drive theatre attendance
- Marketing also positions the film for its target demographic, manages critical reception expectations, and extends the film's commercial life through ancillary markets including OTT platforms, home video, and merchandise

20. Importance of Documentation During Film Production

- Production documentation — including call sheets, shot lists, continuity reports, script supervisor notes, and production reports — ensures that all departments are coordinated and working from the same information
- Continuity documentation specifically records costume, makeup, prop placement, and actor position between takes, preventing visible inconsistencies in the edited film
- Thorough documentation protects the production legally, facilitates post-production by providing editors and VFX teams with accurate records, and serves as an institutional memory for the entire filmmaking process

21. Use of Sound Design in Motion Pictures

- Sound design encompasses all non-dialogue audio elements — ambient sound, sound effects, Foley, and music — that together create the acoustic world of a film and guide emotional response
- Effective sound design establishes place and atmosphere, signals danger or comfort, reinforces visual action, and directs audience attention to narratively significant elements within the frame
- Sound designers use contrast, silence, and layered audio to manipulate tension and pacing; landmark sound design works such as those in Apocalypse Now and Interstellar demonstrate how sound is as narratively powerful as the image itself

22. Importance of Makeup Continuity

- Makeup continuity ensures that an actor's appearance — skin tone, wounds, ageing effects, hairstyle — remains consistent across all shots within a scene, regardless of the order in which they are filmed
- Since films are almost never shot in chronological sequence, continuity errors in makeup can create jarring inconsistencies visible to audiences in the edited film
- The makeup continuity supervisor maintains detailed photographic records of each actor's look for every scene, enabling precise replication across shooting days and ensuring seamless narrative coherence in the final cut

PART C — Essay Questions *(15 Marks)*

23. Narrative Innovations in "Life of an American Fireman" and "The Great Train Robbery"

- Life of an American Fireman (Edwin S. Porter, 1903) was among the first films to use editing to construct a narrative across multiple locations, interweaving shots of a fire station interior with exterior rescue scenes to tell a cause-and-effect story.
- Narrative Innovations - Porter's use of the close-up , the film experimented with parallel editing. The Great Train Robbery (Porter, 1903) advanced narrative cinema further by structuring a multi-scene story with a clear beginning, middle, and end, using location changes, chase sequences, and cross-cutting to create momentum
- Its famous closing shot — a bandit firing his revolver directly at the camera — introduced the concept of direct audience address and demonstrated cinema's capacity for visceral, immediate emotional impact

24. Representation of Women in Contemporary Malayalam Films

- **Application level – (Possible points)** - Contemporary Malayalam films increasingly feature women in professional roles — journalists, police officers, doctors — and narratives that centre female desire, ambition, and trauma without reducing characters to male-defined functions
- However, contradictions persist: item numbers, male gaze cinematography, and token female characters in mainstream commercial films remain common, suggesting that progressive representation coexists with persistent patriarchal conventions.
- The new wave of Malayalam women filmmakers — including Anjali Menon and Geetu Mohandas — is reshaping representational norms from behind the camera, ensuring that female experience is depicted with authenticity and complexity

25. The Complete Process of the Production Stage

- Pre-production completion — the production stage formally begins once all pre-production elements are in place: a locked script, signed cast and crew, secured locations, completed storyboards, and a detailed shooting schedule prepared by the assistant director
- Principal photography — the core of the production stage involves daily shooting according to the call sheet, which schedules which scenes will be filmed, which cast members are required, and what equipment is needed each day
- Direction and performance — the director works with actors to realise performances, guides the director of photography on shot composition and camera movement, and makes real-time creative decisions to capture the script's vision
- Cinematography and lighting — the DoP and gaffer design and execute lighting setups for each scene, ensuring visual consistency, appropriate mood, and technically sound exposure throughout the shoot
- Sound recording — the production sound mixer and boom operator capture clean dialogue and on-set audio using boom microphones and lavalier mics, as poor production sound is difficult and expensive to fix in post
- Continuity and documentation — the script supervisor monitors continuity of costume, makeup, props, and performance between takes; daily production reports track footage shot, setups completed, and any schedule deviations
- Daily review — dailies (rushes) are reviewed by the director and producer at the end of each shooting day to assess performance and technical quality, enabling reshoots to be scheduled before the production moves on

26. Importance of Film Analysis in Understanding Cinema

- Application level – (Possible points) - Film analysis is the systematic examination of a film's formal elements — narrative structure, cinematography, editing, sound, performance, and mise-en-scène — to understand how meaning is constructed and communicated to audiences
- It moves the viewer beyond passive consumption to active critical engagement, revealing how filmmakers use the grammar of cinema — shot selection, colour, music, framing — to guide emotional response and convey ideology. Analysing narrative structure through frameworks such as three-act structure, the hero's journey, or non-linear storytelling helps students understand how films create dramatic tension, character development, and thematic coherence
- Film analysis situates individual films within their historical, cultural, and political contexts — understanding Pather Panchali requires knowledge of post-independence India; reading Metropolis demands awareness of Weimar-era anxieties about industrialisation and class.
- Genre analysis reveals how films both conform to and subvert audience expectations, while auteur theory allows analysis of a filmmaker's recurring stylistic and thematic concerns across a body of work.